SAMPLE

Yusuf: The Dreamer Who Became the King of Egypt

The Story of Prophet Yusuf (يوسف) in the Quran and Islamic Tradition

Aira Aurora

Free sample: Introduction & Chapter 1

putrabooks.github.io

Introduction

Yusuf (عليه السلام) is the prophet whose life was a series of descents and ascents. He descended from his father's love into a well. He descended from the well into slavery. He descended from slavery into prison. And then he ascended -- from prison to the palace, from the dungeon to the throne, from the lowest place in Egypt to the second-highest.

The Quran calls his story "the most beautiful of stories":

"We relate to you the best of stories in what We have revealed to you of this Quran, though you were before it among the unaware" (12:3).

Ahson al-qasas -- the best, the most beautiful of stories. The Quran does not use this phrase for any other narrative. Yusuf's story is unique -- not because the events are unique but because the telling is unique. The story has a literary beauty that the Quran itself acknowledges: a coherent, unified, emotionally powerful narrative that reads like a novel and teaches like a revelation.

The story of Yusuf is the story of a life governed by divine providence -- a life in which every event, every circumstance, every twist and turn was part of a plan that Yusuf could not see but never stopped trusting. The boy who was thrown into a well became the man who saved his family from famine. The slave who was sold for a few dirhams became the minister who controlled the grain of the most powerful nation on earth. The prisoner who was forgotten in a dungeon became the ruler who sat beside the Pharaoh's throne.

Yusuf's story is connected to his father Yaqub's -- the two stories are inseparable. The father's patience and the son's perseverance are two halves of the same narrative. But while Yaqub's story is about waiting, Yusuf's story is about surviving. Yaqub waited; Yusuf endured. Yaqub wept; Yusuf worked. Yaqub held on to hope; Yusuf held on to Allah.

This book traces Yusuf's story through the Quran: the dream, the well, the slavery, the trial, the prison, the rise, the reunion, and the lessons. It is the eleventh light in the NurOne - The Prophets series -- the light that went down and came back up, the light that was tested in every way and passed every test, the light that proves that the plan of Allah is always more beautiful than the plan of those who plot against it.

Chapter 1: The Dream and the Well

The Quran begins Yusuf's story with a dream:

"When Yusuf said to his father: O my father, indeed I have seen eleven stars and the sun and the moon -- I saw them prostrating to me" (12:4).

Eleven stars, the sun, the moon. The imagery was clear to any dream-interpreter: eleven brothers (the stars), two parents (the sun and moon), all in submission to Yusuf. The dream was a prophecy -- a divine preview of a future in which Yusuf would be elevated above his entire family.

Yaqub recognized the significance immediately:

"He said: O my son, do not relate your vision to your brothers, lest they plot against you a plan. Indeed, Satan is to man a clear enemy" (12:5).

Yaqub's response reveals three things:

He believed the dream. He did not dismiss it as a child's fantasy. He treated it as a divine communication -- a prophecy that would be fulfilled.

He feared the consequences. He knew that if the brothers learned of the dream, their jealousy would turn to violence. A dream of superiority, told to those who already felt inferior, was dangerous.

He saw the larger pattern. "Satan is to man a clear enemy." Yaqub recognized that the jealousy was not just human emotion; it was the whisper of Satan, who seeks to destroy the bonds between people -- especially the bonds of family.

"And thus will your Lord choose you and teach you the interpretation of events and complete His favor upon you and upon the family of Yaqub, as He completed it upon your fathers before, Ibrahim and Ishaq. Indeed, your Lord is Knowing and Wise" (12:6).

Allah confirmed the dream through Yaqub's understanding. Yusuf would be chosen. He would be taught the interpretation of events -- *ta'wil al-ahadith* -- the ability to read meaning in dreams and circumstances. And the favor of Allah, which had been upon Ibrahim and Ishaq, would continue upon Yusuf and the family of Yaqub.

The brothers' jealousy was already present before the dream:

"When they said: Yusuf and his brother are more beloved to our father than we are, while we are a band. Indeed, our father is in clear error" (12:8).

The brothers identified the problem: Yaqub loved Yusuf and Benjamin more. The two sons of Rachel -- the beloved wife -- were the favorites. The ten older sons, from Leah and the handmaids, felt excluded. Their complaint was not unreasonable: a father's unequal love is painful. But their response -- to call their father "in clear error" -- was a step beyond complaint into disrespect.

The Quran's honesty here is important. Yaqub was a prophet. He was not perfect in his parenting. The Quran does not defend his favoritism. It presents the family as it was -- with real dynamics, real tensions, real pain on all sides. The brothers' jealousy was human. The brothers' response to that jealousy -- violence -- was criminal.

"Kill Yusuf or cast him away into some land, and the face of your father will be free for you, and after that you will be a righteous people" (12:9).

The brothers plotted. Two options: kill Yusuf or abandon him somewhere far away. The goal: remove the competition for their father's love. And then, remarkably: "after that you will be a righteous people." The brothers planned a crime and then claimed they would be righteous afterward -- a self-deception that the Quran exposes with surgical precision.

A speaker among them offered a third option:

"Said a speaker among them: Do not kill Yusuf but cast him into the bottom of the well. Some travelers will pick him up -- if you must do something" (12:10).

This was the compromise: don't kill him, just abandon him. The well option was presented as more humane -- a way to get rid of Yusuf without directly killing him. But the intention was the same: eliminate the brother, remove the competition. The speaker's suggestion that "some travelers will pick him up" was either naïveté or cruelty -- the brothers did not care what happened to Yusuf after they disposed of him.

"They said: O our father, why do you not entrust us with Yusuf while we are his sincere advisers?" (12:11).

The brothers approached Yaqub with feigned concern. They presented themselves as protectors -- "sincere advisers" -- hiding their murderous intent. The Quran exposes the gap between their words and their hearts: they spoke of care while planning harm.

Yaqub resisted. He expressed his fear -- "I fear that a wolf would eat him" (12:13). But the brothers pressed:

"If a wolf eats him while we are a band, then indeed we are losers" (12:14).

Their argument was logical: eleven strong men cannot fail to protect one boy from a wolf. Yaqub's fear was, from a practical standpoint, unreasonable. But the fear was prophetic -- a father's instinct sensing danger that his mind could not prove. The brothers won the argument through logic, and Yaqub, against his better judgment, let Yusuf go.

"So when they went with him and agreed to put him into the bottom of the well, and We revealed to him: You will surely inform them of this affair while they do not perceive" (12:15).

They threw him in. The Quran does not describe the physical act in detail. The brevity is powerful: they agreed to put him into the bottom of the well. The word *ghayabat al-jubb* -- the hidden depths of the well -- conveys darkness, isolation, abandonment. Yusuf was alone, in the dark, at the bottom of a dry cistern.

But Allah revealed something to him: "You will surely inform them of this affair while they do not perceive." At the moment of maximum despair -- alone in a well, betrayed by his brothers -- Allah gave Yusuf a promise: you will tell them about this. You will confront them. And they will not know that you are doing it. The promise was a seed of hope planted in the darkest place. Yusuf did not know how the promise would be fulfilled, but he knew it would be.

The Quran adds:

"Thus We established Yusuf in the land, that We might teach him the interpretation of events. And Allah is predominant over His affair, but most of the people do not know" (12:21, from a later verse, but theologically connected).

The well was not the end. It was the beginning. The descent was the first step in a journey that would end in the palace. Allah was predominant -- in control -- over every event, including the betrayal. The brothers meant it for evil; Allah meant it for good. Most people do not know this. They see the event and not the plan. They see the well and not the ascent.

"And they came to their father at night, weeping. They said: O our father, indeed we went racing each other and left Yusuf with our possessions, and a wolf ate him" (12:16-17).

The brothers returned without Yusuf. They came at night -- the darkness a cover for their deception. They wept -- the tears manufactured, the grief performed. The story: a wolf ate Yusuf. The very thing Yaqub had feared. The very fear the brothers had mocked. Now they used it as their alibi.

"But you would not believe us even if we were truthful." The brothers added this line -- a manipulation, preempting their father's doubt. They presented themselves as victims of their father's skepticism, turning the focus from their story to Yaqub's response.

Yaqub was not deceived:

"He said: Rather, your souls have enticed you to something. So patience is most fitting. And Allah is the one sought for help against that which you describe" (12:18).

Fa-sabrun jamil -- patience is most fitting. These two words became the defining statement of Yaqub's life. The patience that is beautiful. The patience that grieves but does not break. The patience that knows the truth but does not punish, that feels the pain but does not despair.

"And there came a caravan, and they sent their water drawer. He let down his bucket and said: Good news! Here is a boy" (12:19).

A caravan passed by the well. A water drawer lowered his bucket and pulled up a boy. The discovery was accidental -- from the caravan's perspective. But from Allah's perspective, it was the first step in the plan. The well was not a grave; it was a departure point.

"And they concealed him as merchandise. And Allah knew what they did" (12:19).

The brothers sold Yusuf. The Quran does not specify the price here, but later says: "And they sold him for a reduced price -- a few dirhams -- and they were of him unconcerned" (12:20).

A few dirhams. The brothers who plotted to eliminate their rival sold him for pocket change. The Quran emphasizes their indifference: "they were of him unconcerned." They did not care who bought him, where he was taken, or what happened to him. The boy was disposable. The rivalry was the point.

The Quran's assessment: "And they were of him unconcerned." This is the Quran's diagnosis of envy: the envious person does not value what they take. They do not even value the act of taking. They are simply indifferent to the person they have harmed. The envy consumed the value; the person was nothing.